Tale as old as time

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25910089.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

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by dragonesdepapel

Summary

"I won't be back until the seasons change twice, at least. Maybe longer. We won't see each other for a while."

"Promise you won't forget about me?"

She-Ra smiled. "I promise."

Princess Catra's life has been tainted with tragedy since she was a child. Her parents were murdered, the woman who was put in charge of her kigdom despises her, and she can't trust anyone inside her own castle. While running away from it, however, she makes a friend, one who will stay by her side for most of her life. But it looks like the girl who dreams of being a knight has some secrets of her own.

Notes

So I decided that in the spirit of making good things happen for myself, that I should gift myself the chance to work on a fic I was very excited about, and then post it on my birthday. I should've accounted for the fact that I wouldn't get to post till almost one am and that my brain is fried by that time, so I just hope I don't wake up tomorrow and find that I made a terrible mistake somewhere in the description or the notes lmao The fic itself is fine, don't worry, but like, I did start writing the author's note on the description box before I realized my mistake so it's really something I should keep in mind from now on :p

A million thanks to the wonderful, amazing, increíble Nny11 for betaing this. Like, seriously, so many thanks. An

incommensurable amount of thanks. If you like this fic you should totally go read theirs because they are amazing and this fic wouldn't be as good without their help.

And @ sadiewrites, thanks for encouraging me to write this and for cheering me on and for listening to me talking about it so much lol I hope it's everything you dreamed!!

See the end of the work for more notes

Princess Catra's story began, purportedly, when she was born. The issue was, there had not been anyone around who remembered those times in a very long while. Princess Catra's story, thusly, was forced to begin a few months after she turned two years old. That night, while she was laying on her royal cot, a group of assassins broke into her parent's, the Queen and King of D'riluth, chamber and murdered them in cold blood. They left the cot untouched, but that didn't stop Princess Catra from waking up crying; a thing she would do many times in the years to come.

The Princess's comfort, however, was relegated to a secondary concern as the kingdom had suddenly found itself leaderless. It was decided, then, that the Royal Advisor, who had been by the late Queen and King's side for many years, would be appointed Regent and that she would take over all royal decisions until Princess Catra would come of age and be able to take the throne for herself. Regent Weaver was, naturally, also put in charge of the Princess's education and care. Private tutors took over the first one, while the second one went neglected for most of Catra's youth. The lessons Regent Weaver would instill in the young royal were of dominance and fear, and designed to slowly eat away at Catra's own sense of self.

The court, of course, knew nothing of this, and only saw of their relationship what Regent Weaver considered fit. In any case, as time went by the courtiers, the generals, and even the maids and cooks – in short; everyone who had once been esteemed and trusted by the Queen and King, were slowly pushed away from the castle. Those who could be disposed of were promptly dealt with. Those who couldn't were replaced. And those who not even the Regent herself had enough power to remove suddenly found themselves devoid of any influence they had possessed before. The changes were carried out swiftly and covertly, with the end result being that soon there was no one around who either could or would take any action against the Regent and her rule.

As bleak as the beginning of this tale might sound, it is only that; a beginning. For Princess Catra's story is one of bravery and,

above it all, it is a story of love. In fact, though it's true that some years would have to pass from that tragic night before the princess could experience true happiness again, they weren't as many as one might fear.

And that's when the next chapter of her life began.

Unbecoming of a princess as it might be, Catra developed the habit of sneaking out of her lessons and chores as early as her being a four-year-old. She got caught a lot at first, but that didn't deter her in the slightest. By the time she turned five she had become so good at hiding and sneaking around that she could evade her ever-present escort and even go beyond the castle's grounds and into town.

The first couple of incursions of this variety were mostly fruitless. Not more than tests of ability which soon proved that, while she was able of escaping her royal prison for a short period of time, she didn't have the first idea of what to do once this was accomplished.

It was during one of these adventures when things finally started falling into place for the young princess. Catra had managed to get out of the castle, and was vaguely aware of the path she had to take to get herself to the marketplace, but it was not without a cost. She had been spotted and followed, and so far, she hadn't managed to shake them off her trail. She'd had the "pleasure" of joining Regent Weaver for breakfast that morning, where she had been made aware of the foul mood Weaver found herself in. Being dragged back to the castle to be disciplined was not an appealing option. It would be much better to wait it out and then walk back in herself. If she pretended to have been inside the whole afternoon, most guards would quickly ease off her back, no matter how blatant her lies were. After all, they might be rewarded for turning in a fugitive princess, but not so much for admitting to having lost her and failing to find her. No, the danger, at least for now, resided solely on getting caught.

Such were her concerns when, forgetting to look ahead, she collided with someone.

"Watch where you are going, you dumb face," yelled Catra at the person, who turned out to be a kid like her.

She had a basket on one hand and was wearing a heavy cloak that covered her whole body. The force of their impact had thrown back the hood, revealing the face hidden underneath. Blonde hair was kept up by a ribbon and stormy gray eyes were looking at Catra with contempt.

Catra rushed past her, continuing her search for a hiding spot, but the girl only took a second to fix the hood firmly over her head again before following her.

"That's a very rude word," the girl said, quickening her pace to match Catra's, "my aunty says we should never be rude."

"I don't care what your aunty says, and I bet she has a dumb face too."

Catra threw a look behind her, eager to see the way the stranger's brows would scrunch up at that, but her face was too concealed to be able to tell. What she did notice, however, was a member of the guard looking over the crowd. Without thinking, Catra jumped and hid herself behind some wooden crates someone had left on the street. It wasn't a foolproof plan, but it was the only one she had. She had always been a small kid, and if she crouched and kept still, he might walk right next to her without noticing.

"Kid," she heard a male voice yell. "You, the one with the cloak. Stop right there."

Catra found a gap between the crates and wasted no time in pushing her face against it, eager to see what happened.

The girl stopped in her tracks and, for a second, Catra saw her looking around, probably looking for a place to hide too. She started walking towards the end of the street, getting ready to

run, but a man chose that moment to get in her way, sending her back to the ground for the second time in so many minutes. The guard approached her, and held her up with a hand on her arm while he pushed her hood back with the other. He searched her face for any resemblance to Catra.

"Is there a problem?" the girl asked, a determined expression on her face which Catra found hilarious. The gap between her teeth didn't make her in any way intimidating.

The man let her go. "Have you seen any other girls you age around? One with brown hair and different colored eyes?"

"Why? What did she do?"

The man grew agitated. "That's none of your concern."

He walked away, examining the crowds once again, forgetting that the girl hadn't answered his question.

Catra sighed, calculating her next step.

A voice sounded next to her ear. "Are you a thief?"

She yelped in surprise, and turned to find that the girl had appeared next to her.

"I'm not a thief," Catra answered with distaste.

"Then why are those men looking for you?" There was no judgement in her tone, just plain curiosity.

Catra didn't have time for this. She had hoped she would finally get to explore the market this time. She had even brought along some coins she had pilfered from courtiers' pockets. That was the most dangerous of her games, one Regent Weaver would have her head for if she ever found out. But now it looked like it would be best if she cut her losses and went back before anyone could find her out here.

“Because they are dumb too, ok?”

The girl tilted her head. “Is that the only word you know?”

Catra groaned in frustration. “If you must really know, I’m the princess of this land.” She held her head up. “I sneaked out of the castle and now I have to go back before they find me out here.”

The girl froze. Catra could feel her seizing her up. Her first instinct was to panic and flee but, before she could, the girl was already taking off her cloak and sliding it over Catra’s shoulders. She stepped closer to adjust the hood over her head. The full intensity of the girl’s gaze hit Catra again, and it was with the utmost solemnity that she said, “Follow me.”

She grabbed Catra by the hand and led her through a maze of streets in such a hurry that the princess quickly lost her sense of direction. Despite her fast pace, the girl seemed to be aware of everything that was going on around them, and sometimes changed directions to avoid guards before Catra would even notice they were close by.

The grip on her hand didn’t ease up until they found themselves on a different, far less busy street. Catra couldn’t tell much about where they were, except that it wasn’t a shop street.

“I can’t go any further,” the girl said, letting go of her hand and looking expectantly at Catra.

“Where are we?”

“If you go ahead through this street you’ll be just at the edge of town, and you should be able to make your way back to the castle without any problems. You don’t know your way around your own land?”

Catra glared. “A princess does not often mingle with the townspeople. We have more important things to do.”

The girl opened her mouth, a contrary glint on her eye, but nothing came out. They stood there, looking at each other.

“I will need my cloak back.”

Catra fiddled with the cloth. She didn’t want to leave; she hadn’t had time to do anything but run and hide today. All that effort, wasted. Perhaps getting to walk around a little more would be worth the disciplining she would have to endure if she was found.

“What’s wrong?” asked the girl, because apparently no one had ever taught her not to bother royalty when they were deep in thought.

“I don’t want to go back yet.”

“So don’t.”

“But I will get in trouble if I don’t.”

The girl tilted her head. “Then do.”

Catra considered pushing her for being an annoyance, but discarded the idea. It would be beneath her. “It’s not that easy.”

“Why do you want to stay here anyway? You don’t even know the town.”

“It’s not something a commoner like you would understand.”

The girl smiled. “Probably.”

Her sounds were too rounded for the word, probably because of the gap between her front teeth. And the lack of formal lessons, which Catra envied her for, if she was being honest. She envied everything about her. The fact that she was just a girl, going about her day. She wasn’t a princess, she didn't have responsibilities and duties. She didn’t have to live up to Regent Weaver impossible expectations. She didn’t have to hide and sneak and lie and deceive just to get a breath of fresh air.

“I wanted to visit the market,” she said, her voice small.

A hand found Catra’s, giving it a light squeeze. The girl looked pensive for a moment.

“Can you get back here in three days' time?”

Catra thought about it. It was risky to play this game again so soon after today. She decided she didn't really care. She nodded, and was rewarded for it with a huge grin on the girl’s face.

“Then, I will escort you on your trip to the market, princess.”

“Don’t call me princess,” she snapped without even thinking, but she recovered quickly. “After all, we don’t want anyone overhearing it, right?”

The girl nodded.

“What’s your name?” Catra asked.

“She-Ra.”

She frowned. “That’s a weird name.”

She-Ra puffed up her cheeks. “No, it’s not! My aunty says...”

“Do you know anything outside of what your aunt tells you?”

“Yes. Do you know anything outside of what happens in your palace?”

Catra paused for a minute. “...yes.”

She-Ra arched her eyebrows.

“Maybe not. But you’ll show me, right?”

“I’m not from this town, I’m here...” she hesitated for a second. “Visiting my aunt.”

“Is that why you talk about her so much?”

She-Ra looked troubled for some reason. “It’s a different aunt.”

Catra didn’t actually care about the girl’s family matters. “But you’ll show me around?”

Her expression cleared. “Yes, I can do that.”

“Then that’s enough. I’ll be here, but you might have to wait a little for me.”

“Bring a cloak. Not a showy one, one in muted colors, like mine,” She-Ra said.

Catra didn’t even know if she owned any kind of cloaks, but she nodded. She took out She-Ra's and passed it back to her, who put it back on immediately. Catra took a last look at her obscured face before turning around and making her way back to the palace.

In the end, fortune decided to smile upon the princess. She managed to get back to her room without any trouble, and was there to receive a message from the regent asking for her company at dinner. It wasn’t a pleasant affair, but it wasn’t terrible either. Other members of the court were present, and all Princess Catra had to do was eat her food in silence, and ignore the intense looks Regent Weaver kept sending her way.

That night, after she had retired to her chambers and she was left alone, she went over her belongings, trying to find a cloak like She-Ra had instructed her to. She found one that she hadn’t worn in a long time. It was a little small on her, but it would have to do.

During the next few days, Princess Catra was on her best behavior. She listened to her lessons, worked on her embroidering, and even kept her shoes on all day. Most of the day, at least. Then, on the agreed morning, she feigned feeling unwell and wanting to retire to her chambers. No one actually cared enough to stop her from doing exactly that, as long as she

wasn’t acting out in a complete unladylike manner, so she was left alone. She put on her cloak, and she left.

She had made sure to memorize her way from the castle to the place She-Ra was waiting for her, and found returning wasn’t too hard. The other girl was already there, basket in her hand, hood in place. The sun was shining bright, and it was probably a good way for her to protect her face from it. Catra rushed to her, the anticipation of the last few days filling her with energy.

She-Ra greeted her, and started leading her around the small streets. She chattered along the way about what little she knew about the town. Soon, they found themselves at the market. The streets were much busier here, lots of people were walking around, and the conversations of merchants and buyers filled the air. She-Ra had to acquire some things for her aunt, so Catra followed her around as she did so. She got to buy a loaf of bread at the baker’s shop, and they shared it sitting on the floor out of the way.

Catra told She-Ra what she had learned in her lessons. The town was actually pretty large as towns went. This was because of its strategic placement, right at the joint of three of the kingdom's most important roads, as well as its proximity to the royal castle. Many merchants came from villages nearby to sell their goods, and there were even festivals organized at different times of the year.

“And what are they like?”

“I don’t know, I’ve never been to one.”

After they were done, they walked back to their meeting point, and once again, She-Ra stayed in place as soon as they reached it. Just like before, Catra didn’t want to leave. She had had fun. Real fun, not the kind that came from mocking guards or getting away with skipping her lessons.

“Can we do this again tomorrow?”

She-Ra shook her head. “I’m leaving tonight.”

It was probably for the best. She didn’t want to push her luck too much. She remembered the last time she had been caught trying to get away from the castle. Her side had ached for a week. That didn’t stop the tightness on her chest. She didn’t want to lose this. She didn’t want to lose She-Ra.

“Don’t be sad. I won’t be gone forever. I’ll come back to visit my aunt another time.”

“When?”

Now it was She-Ra's turn to be sad. “I don’t know.”

Tears threatened to fall from Catra’s eyes. “Then how will I know when to look for you?”

They stayed in silence for a couple of minutes. Finally, She-Ra spoke again.

“I have an idea.”

Once again, she took Catra’s hand and she led her to a different set of streets.

“See that house over there? The one with the flowers on the door.”

Catra nodded.

“I’ll leave a red ribbon on them next time I’m in town, and you’ll know that I’ll be waiting for you at our usual spot. It's not perfect but...”

“It’s good enough.”

“I won’t be back until the seasons change twice, at least. Maybe longer. We won’t see each other for a while.”

“Promise you won’t forget about me?”

She-Ra smiled. “I promise.”

After the encounter, the princess's behavior changed. Knowing that there was someone out there who thought about her, who appreciated her company, who had something for her other than ill will and political intentions, it somehow made life at the castle more bearable. She didn’t feel as oppressed by the heavy atmosphere as she did before, and she stopped taking every advantage to wreak havoc among those who were charged with looking after her. Everyone was relieved to see her progress, even though they could have never guessed the cause of it.

Far from making the people around her grow fonder of the princess, however, this only led to more indifference. Catra had long learned that the only way to get attention was by rebelling, and that was the way she had conducted herself so far. But now she found that she preferred the freedom that came with being left alone to her own devices. No one minded what she did as long as she complied with the basic rules that were set for her, and she couldn’t be more grateful for it. It was lonely, being the only child in a grown-up's world, but every time Catra felt alone, she could picture She-Ra's smile, and the stories she had told her, and imagine the day they would get to be together again.

Regent Weaver’s treatment of her didn’t really improve, but it didn’t get worse, at least. She still criticized everything about the princess, from her hair to her diction, and she had a penchant for reminding her about her parent’s cruel fate whenever Catra made a mistake in her presence. “ *You need to do better,”* she would say, “ *if you don’t want to end up like them.”* Even though the princess was young, every part of her body burned with hatred for the regent. Her lips were often bruised, so strong she had to bite them to stop herself from snapping back.

Spring passed, and then so did summer, and finally the princess could feel her friend’s return growing nearer and nearer. But autumn started growing into winter, and still, Princess Catra didn’t catch a glimpse of red on the signaled door. She started thinking that She-Ra would not come at all. Then, she feared that She-Ra's

trip had come and gone, and that she had missed it all together. Finally, she decided that her friend had broken their promise, and had, in fact, forgotten all about Catra and their two-day adventure.

That didn't stop her from checking in on it every time she could get away from watchful eyes. At last, one day, she saw it. A red ribbon, right where She-Ra said it would be. She rushed towards the place they had agreed to meet, and there she found her. She-Ra ran towards her as soon as she saw her, hugging her when they finally found themselves face to face. She-Ra talked about how much she had missed her, and how she was so worried that Catra would miss her visit, and about all the things they could do together, and Catra forgot all about broken promises and missed encounters.

The first several years passed like that. They didn't see each other much, but each time brought more joy than Princess Catra could have felt in all the months they spent apart altogether. She-Ra usually stayed at her aunt's house for a month, and they both managed to get away from their obligations one or two times a week to meet. She-Ra had told her that she needed to be careful too. After all, they didn't want her aunt figuring out who her new friend was. She advised for Catra to never stay too long near the house with flowers at its door, and there were times when Catra waited for her and she never appeared, so she had to go back to the castle and hope the failed excursion hadn't cost her another day with She-Ra.

Then, one afternoon, right as she was saying goodbye to her friend, she saw her freeze in place. Catra was going to ask what was wrong, but She-Ra quickly hugged her and fled. Catra turned to look at her go, and she found an old woman looking at them. She wore a colorful robe, and her hair was completely white. Her gaze unnerved her, so Catra found herself in a hurry to leave too.

The princess couldn't find another moment to slip away from the castle until four days later, and she found herself extremely anxious as she waited for the opportunity to arrive. A part of her

thought she was making a mistake by going back. She-Ra had always been very careful about not being seen together, and Catra had seen the fear in her eyes when she had realized they had been spotted. Would her aunt turn Catra in? Would she be brought back to the castle and locked up in her chambers for the rest of her life? Princess Catra didn't doubt that it would be a likely future if the regent ever found out about her escapades.

In the end, she couldn't stay away from She-Ra. She had to at least try to see her. But all her worries turned out to be for nothing. She-Ra was waiting for her when she showed up, and her grin was as big as it ever was when she saw Catra that morning.

"My aunt says you can come to her house," she said on Catra's ear as she hugged her.

She took her there, with the usual swiftness She-Ra conducted herself. Once they found themselves inside, however, her demeanor altered. She took off her cloak, the first time she had ever done so apart from the day Catra had first known her. Her smile looked more relaxed, and Catra enjoyed the opportunity to look more deeply into her eyes.

"You don't like being outside," Catra guessed.

"It's not safe for a princess to be out and about," She-Ra said automatically, the way she sometimes did.

Catra snorted. "Did your aunt tell you that?"

She-Ra avoided her eyes, focusing instead on fixing her hair, which had grown a little frazzled from being under the hood all that time.

The princess quickly forgot about it. She had never been inside a peasant's house before. In fact, she had never been inside anywhere except for the castle and some of the market's shops. She wanted to commit the image to memory. Not that there was

much to see. The place was small, the furniture was sparse. Was this how She-Ra lived?

She wished she could see her real house. She wished she could take her to the castle. Not because she wanted to show it off to her, there was nothing in that place that mattered to Catra. But maybe having her friend there would change it. Maybe some of She-Ra's warmth would be strong enough to linger in those rooms even after she was gone.

Catra quickly found that being able to stay inside and out of sight did wonders for She-Ra’s disposition. She laughed a little louder and a little longer, she didn’t jump at any person that got close to them. Catra hadn’t realized how anxious She-Ra had always been until then. Things she thought were part of the other girl’s personality turned out to be just products of stress. It also allowed them to spend more time together, as now Catra didn’t have to turn around and leave the days She-Ra's chores kept her inside the house.

She also got to know She-Ra's aunt, Razz, who turned out to be the weirdest person the princess had met so far. She would give Catra the strangest pieces of advice at the most random of times. She would interrupt their conversations to ask questions that had nothing to do with the topic at hand. But she would also forward Catra’s letters to She-Ra, and she would always greet her with a smile and a piece of pie.

As they grew, Catra realized that She-Ra wasn’t a simple peasant’s daughter. It was clear she had received an education, and was able to keep up with Catra in every possible topic. When they were kids, She-Ra would always talk about how she wouldd grow up to be a knight, and, at first, Catra had assumed it was little more than a child’s wish. But She-Ra had, in fact, gone onto become a page and then, a squire. Most times, Catra would arrive at Razz’s house to find She-Ra running through different fighting techniques.

Catra liked watching her train. She would sit in a corner, and admire the way her friend, who was usually a clumsy mess, became agile and precise.

“Can you teach me?” she said one day.

It was a summer morning, and it was way too hot to be doing any kind of physical activity, but if She-Ra could do it, then so could Catra.

She-Ra stopped mid movement, lowering the wooden stick she used to practice. “You want to learn sword-fighting?”

Catra nodded, getting up from the floor and searching for another stick.

“Don’t you think a royal instructor would be more suited for the task, your Highness?”

She-Ra didn’t address Catra as a princess often, she had always respected her childish wish to avoid it. Now that they were in their teens, however, she had grown more and more comfortable letting it slip into the conversation when she thought it’d give her some kind of leverage.

Catra snorted. “As if Weaver would let me get anywhere near a sharp edge.”

Her friend’s face scrunched up in concern. “Princess...”

Her title also made an appearance when She-Ra was worried about her, which Catra preferred not to think about. If she did, if she let herself linger on the way She-Ra's eyes would crinkle around the edges, the way her voice went quiet and soft, the way it sounded on her tongue... Then Catra would have to also think about the way her stomach filled with warmth when she heard it and her heart beat so fast it felt like it was about to leave her ribcage. And those were thoughts that were best left alone.

“So, are you going to teach me or not?” She mimicked the starting position she had seen She-Ra do a million times before. “Unless you are scared I’ll be better than you.”

This time it was She-Ra's turn to snort. “Please, I’ve been training for years.”

Catra didn’t wait for her to finish the phrase before lunging forward with her stick. She aimed for She-Ra's stomach, but she got blocked. She changed course, going for her shoulder instead. Again, She-Ra had no trouble stopping her blow. She let Catra do another couple of attempts at hitting her before she charged. Catra managed to avoid the first attack, and she also stopped the second one. That was when She-Ra did a complicated move with her wrist that ended up with Catra losing the grip of her stick and it falling to the ground.

“That was actually really impressive! I think you are a natural, you’ll learn this in no time. Now, do the starting stance again, your feet were too far apart the first time.”

At that point, She-Ra had started travelling to town more frequently, and they usually got to see each other twice or thrice a year, but that still wasn’t enough to make the princess an accomplished swordswoman. Still, Catra did her best. She-Ra was a good teacher, and Catra applied herself harder to swordplay than to anything she had ever done. She memorized the lessons and then practiced them alone in the months she didn’t get to see her friend. Neither of them mentioned it, but they both knew the motivations hidden behind her request.

The environment at the castle, in contrast to Razz’s home, had only grown hostile in the years that had gone by. Catra was smart, and she knew how fragile her standing in her own kingdom was. Regent Weaver certainly didn’t shy away from telling the princess exactly how useful she thought she was. Catra might have been the one with a legitimate title, but Weaver was the one who held actual power. The court had no respect for Catra, not after being poisoned by the regent’s stories of Catra’s attitude. Catra wasn’t

even allowed to keep her own maids for more than a couple of months, she presumed, to prevent them from growing attached and favoring the princess. Learning how to defend herself, in any way she could, was Catra's way of retaining some semblance of control.

But despite all of Regent Weaver's machinations, Princess Catra had made friends. She-Ra might have been the first one, but she wasn't the only one. When Catra had turned nine, the castle had received a new guest. Lady Scorpia had been invited to spend her summer with them, and then she hadn't left. Scorpia's mothers were the Duchesses of the Fright Zone, one of the most important pieces of land in the kingdom, since it held the only access to the sea. Lady Scorpia's presence at the castle served as an incentive for them to remember their duty to the royal family, and to dissuade any and all ideas about dissidence. Lady Scorpia was, as far as Catra knew, free to return home at any moment she desired and she often made the trip once a year to visit her mothers, but she always came back, a physical proof of their loyalty.

Despite her role as a political pawn, Lady Scorpia seemed genuinely happy with her living situation. Catra knew that the only reason Regent Weaver had permitted and even encouraged them to bond was because she had complete confidence in Scorpia's compliance. She probably hoped it would rub off on Catra, and that Scorpia's presence around her would encourage the princess to behave more properly. But for once, Regent Weaver's hubris had backfired. Lady Scorpia was loyal to the crown, but Weaver wasn't the crown, Catra was. So while Scorpia would never act against the regent's expressed wishes, she had no qualms hiding Princess Catra's own misbehaviors.

Of course, Catra hadn't trusted her at first. She knew of Scorpia's reputation, and she was sure she would go spill her secrets to the regent as soon as she had them. But, no matter how rude and downright aggressive she was towards her, it didn't damper Scorpia's mood or her attempts at friendship. After all, they were the only kids around. Little by little, Catra learned to let her guard down around her.

It had started when Catra noticed that Lady Scorpia would lie and cover for her, not even blinking before replying to inquiries about where the princess had spent her time. Once, Catra hadn't been careful enough when watching the time, and she had stayed away far longer than usual. By the time she had made it back to her room she knew there would be no way to explain away her absence. It wouldn't be so bad, Catra would just have to say that she had hid away from her responsibilities all day, which would earn her some disciplining, but it wouldn't be as bad as what would happen if they found out she still ventured outside the castle grounds. Everyone believed she had grown out of that particular brand of misbehavior, and the princess knew that, now that she wasn't a child anymore, it would not be tolerated.

She had carefully closed the door behind her and found that she wasn't alone.

"Oh good, you are back!"

Catra jumped in place, startled. "What are you doing here! This is my room!"

Lady Scorpia got up from where she was sitting, apologetic smiled on her face. "I know, this is a terrible breach of your privacy and I'm so, so sorry. But people started asking questions, you know how that is, so I said you were sick and didn't want anyone but me taking care of you. Again, super sorry, it couldn't be helped."

"What are you playing at?" Catra hissed.

"What do you mean?"

Catra approached the older girl, not caring that she was at least three heads taller than her. "You think this is going to make me trust you? That I'm going to spill all my secrets to you? I know you are working with her, so you can forget about it."

Lady Scorpia raised her hands. "Wooo there, Wildcat. I was just trying to help."

“Why would you?”

“Because I want us to be friends?” Catra snorted. Scorpia kept talking. “No, really. I think you are really cool, and I want to be your friend. Listen, you don’t have to tell me anything. I won’t pry, I promise! But I’m not going to stand there not helping when I can. I don’t know if you noticed, but we are kind of on our own here.”

With that, Lady Scorpia left.

After the encounter, Catra went easier on her. She allowed her to take their meals together, and she listened to Scorpia’s constant chatter. Scorpia had been in an accident when she was a toddler. She had fallen from a hill and, though her body had healed, she had lost some mobility in her hands. It prevented her from being able to perform some of the detailed work that things like sewing required, so she preferred to sit by Catra’s side while she worked, telling her stories about her childhood in the Fright Zone. Catra discovered that she genuinely liked spending time t with her. She still watched her, trying to figure out if there was any indication that she could be a threat to her. As months went by, the possibility that Scorpia could be colluding with Regent Weaver behind her back looked more and more improbable.

“You want to know what I do when I get out of the castle?” she finally whispered to her one night.

They were alone in Catra’s chamber. Scorpia had fallen ill, and could barely leave her bed. Catra had been attending to her for a week, and she saw little progress. She had begged Regent Weaver to let them switch rooms until Lady Scorpia got better, since Catra’s was warmer and her bed more comfortable. Regent Weaver’s expression had been as set in stone as it usually was, but she had consented with no more than a passing glib comment about how the princess should not forget her generosity. Catra thought she was scared too, even though she would not admit it. Scorpia’s wellbeing was important, and no-one wanted to have to

send word to the Fright Zone that their heir had passed away while in custody of the Regent.

“You don’t have to tell me, Wildcat. It’s fine.”

Scorpia’s voice was much better, and Catra believed the change of room was doing her some good. Her spirits, on the other hand, were still rather low. She had just confessed to missing her moms, and wishing she could find herself in her own bed, which they still kept ready for her, after all these years.

“No, I want to.” Catra took in a deep breath. She tried, but the words were barely above a whisper. “I meet with someone.”

Scorpia struggled to sit up straighter against the multitude of pillows on her back. “What? With whom?”

“A friend,” Catra said, smiling.

It was nice, talking about this. She had never had the opportunity, never thought about someone finding out about She-Ra with anything but apprehension. She wouldn’t even let herself keep the letters she received from Razz, knowing that there was no place in the castle that was safe from the regent’s evil eyes. It wasn’t all that bad, she liked that it was her own private secret. It was like she had her all for herself. But this was good too. Finally getting to share her.

Catra was thirteen and she knew exactly what Scorpia was thinking about when her eyes grew twice their size.

“It’s not like that!” she yelled, hitting her friend’s shoulder. She did it delicately, not wanting to hurt Scorpia. “She really is just a friend.”

“Your smile says otherwise.”

“Shut up,” she mumbled.

Scorpia mimicked closing her mouth with her hand. The effect was lost when she opened it up again a second later. “So, tell me more about her! What’s she like?”

“Her name is She-Ra, we met years ago, one of the first times I had ran away. She’s not from town, so I don’t get to see her much but...”

And so Princess Catra told her all about She-Ra. She talked about how strong she was, how she was always working hard to make sure she would be a good knight. She told her about how goofy her laugh was, and how sometimes she would speak way too loudly without noticing. She let her in on her theories about She-Ra being from a noble family, and about how she never mentioned it so Catra didn’t dare ask.

She talked and talked, and Scorpia listened to it all. At the end, she only said:

“I’m glad you met her.”

Catra sighed. “I’m glad too.”

After their talk, Scorpia got better within the week, which was a relief for everyone. The only thing that could improve Catra’s mood was getting word from Razz that She-Ra would make the trip to town somewhere in the next month.

They reunited inside Razz’s house, as it was their custom. Catra hugged her, hiding her face on She-Ra's neck. It was getting harder and harder to say goodbye, but Catra tried not to think about that too. She was a princess, she had to be strong. She couldn’t let herself wonder how many times they could do this before her heart finally broke.

“I have something for you,” She-Ra said.

She broke their embrace, and handed Catra a piece of cloth. Catra took it cautiously. It wasn’t the first time She-Ra had tried giving her gifts, but Catra had never been able to accept them. It was

too risky, bringing them back to the castle with her. With the years, She-Ra had changed tactics. She would bring her practical things. Candles, or ink, things that no-one would think twice about the princess having in her chamber. *They'll look exactly the same for anyone else, but you'll see them and think of me.*

But She-Ra wouldn't be this excited about candles. And the gift was definitely heavier than quills.

Catra unwrapped the cloth carefully. Inside, she found a dagger. A beautiful one. The scabbard was black with golden filigrees all over it, as was the handle. A red stone was nested on the pommel. She unleashed it, admiring what, she didn't doubt, was a perfect blade.

She looked up to find She-Ra looking at her, leaning on her tiptoes.

"So, what do you think?"

Catra was speechless. A gift like this...

"Because, remember when you got frustrated because you couldn't get that one move with the sword the last time I was here, and you said it was all pointless anyway because it's not like you could just carry a sword around and what were you going to do, steal it from one of the guards?"

She carefully slid the dagger back to its sheath.

"So I thought that maybe having a knife would be more appropriate? Now that's something that you can carry with you at all times. And that way you won't have to worry about it being found. I didn't have it engraved just in case, of course. I didn't really know how to fight with them, but I spent the last months practicing so we can do that if you want. And...Catra?" She-Ra stopped herself from her babble. "It's ok if you hate it, I promise I won't get upset."

Catra threw herself back into She-Ra's arms. She hadn’t noticed it but tears were falling from her eyes. She-Ra held onto her tightly.

“Princess, I am sorry, just tell me what’s wrong and–”

“I love you,” Catra said, cutting her off.

She-Ra relaxed under her arms, but didn’t ease her grip.

“I love you too, Catra.”

From then on, Princess Catra held onto her gift. She-Ra taught her how to hide it under her robes, how to have quick access to it if the need arose, and, most importantly, how to wield it. It wasn’t the same as having a sword in her hands, but given that the princess had never actually gotten the opportunity to hold a real sword, she thought her dagger suited her just fine. Having it on her person made her feel safer, and knowing who it was from made all the difference. It was the closest she could get to having She-Ra there, looking after her.

Far from diminishing, her feelings for her friend only seemed to grow every day, even when they were apart, or maybe all the more because of it. Some nights Catra lay on her bed, unable to sleep because of how deeply she felt She-Ra's absence. A part of her knew that, no matter how careful they both were, this arrangement of them could not last forever. Something, at some point, would go wrong, and Catra did not know what she’d do when it finally happened.

Regent Weaver had only grown meaner, and her ruling had grown hostile. Messengers brought news of discomfort among the kingdom, and she retaliated with even harsher measures. As for Princess Catra, the regent started taking a more personal interest in her development. This meant , in practice, that Catra got a first seat to witness every fit of bad mood, every harsh word. Her duties increased, to project an image of trust, but in reality, nothing was allowed to be done without the regent’s approval, and even the most minute of details were supervised by her.

Princess Catra's eighteenth birthday came and went without seeing her ascend to the throne. It had been originally stipulated that that would be the date when Regent Weaver would step down from power and give the crown to its rightful heir, but she had managed to convince the court that the princess wasn't ready for the responsibility yet. Catra's nails drew blood from her own palms the day she was informed, and it was the only thing that kept her from lashing out.

Later, she washed the blood as she cried, and she muffled her screams against her pillows. She stabbed them too. She punched and kicked and teared. She hid the mess in one of her trunks, the one that held her travelling clothes even though she had never set a foot outside of her own grounds before. She had never been taught how to ride a horse. But she had been taught how to rule a nation. She had learned politics, and economy, and history, and geography. She was ready, she knew she was! Weaver tried to convince everyone, even her, that she didn't belong here, that she didn't deserve to rule, but Catra had worked hard all her life, and she wouldn't let her take it from her. She wouldn't.

Unless...

That night she dreamed of running away, of leaving the castle and all of her history behind. She'd follow She-Ra, of course, wherever she wanted to go. She'd get to meet her real house. She'd get to see her life. The place where she spent her time away from Catra. She'd meet the people who were lucky enough to see her every day. And she'd get her own life, not this shameful excuse for it that Catra was forced to live in now. She would get to choose what she wanted to spend her time in. She would get to go wherever she wanted to go without having to look over her shoulder at every turn. She'd get to choose the people in her life, and hopefully, if she wasn't ruined for it already, she'd get to trust them too. She would get to be happy. Catra gave herself one night, just one night where she let herself think of abandoning her duties, her rights, her crown, her parent's legacy.

The following day she attended breakfast with a smile on her face and a hand hovering above her hip, where her dagger was hidden. Imagining the violence she could unleash with it made her feel better, even if it was a small comfort.

She decided to work even harder. She made an effort to meet with the courtiers, to prove to them that everything Weaver said were lies. She dressed herself appropriately at all times. She paid even more attention to discussions of the current events along the land. She did her best to influence the people around her, even with Weaver's constant presence at her shoulder.

Regent Weaver didn't do anything to hinder her growing influence around the castle, which proved worrisome. Princess Catra didn't let her guard down for a second, and slept with her dagger on her hand.

Though Catra hadn't had the same luck, there was someone, however, who had passed an important milestone when she turned eighteen.

"Congratulations!" Catra cried as soon as she saw She-Ra.

She threw herself into her arms, as she usually did the first time they saw each other after months of separation, and this time She-Ra did not only catch her but hold her up, spinning them around in Razz's little room. They both laughed freely, knowing that there was no one who could tamper with their joy while they were together. Finally, She-Ra set her down, but she didn't remove her arms from where they were circling Catra's waist. Catra leaned forward, resting her forehead against She-Ra's. She closed her eyes, catching her breath.

"I'm so proud of you."

"Thank you, your Highness."

Catra giggled. "Don't try to ruin the moment."

"I would never dare, your Highness."

The princess stepped back so she could hit her friend on the shoulder.

“Is that how you want to play this? I thought knights were supposed to be chivalrous.”

She-Ra folded her hand to her chest, and bowed. “Please forgive me, your Highness. It is not my intention to cross you.”

“Mhm, so you say. Knights are supposed to wear better clothes too, yet you are still here in the same brown tunic I’ve ever seen you in. Are you sure you were knighted? Are you trying to deceive your princess, commoner?”

The grin on She-Ra's face was the biggest Catra had ever seen on her, and that was saying a lot. She kneeled, letting her head fall. “I am but at your mercy, your Highness. Do with me as you see fit.”

“You are so dumb,” Catra said, laughter breaking up her speech.

On the floor, She-Ra couldn’t contain her laughter any longer either. Her shoulders shook wildly, and she had to prop a hand on the floor to keep herself from falling headfirst into the ground. Catra brought herself to her level, finding it more comfortable to let the laughter pass through her while she was sitting. She laughed so hard tears came to her eyes and, before she knew it, she was crying for entirely different reasons. The change in her emotions was so sudden that she wasn’t able to catch it in time, and she couldn’t do anything but let it follow its course.

Catra brought her hands up to cover her eyes in a futile attempt at getting the tears to stay back. Next to her, She-Ra shifted her stance. Arms wrapped around her, and Catra let them guide her. She-Ra positioned them so she would be the one sitting on the floor, with Catra laying on top of her, her head resting against She-Ra's chest. Catra buried herself on her friend's warmth, selfishly taking it for herself and hoping it’d be enough to scare away her demons. She-Ra ran her fingers through Catra’s hair,

and Catra hugged her waist, and she cried until she thought she'd run herself dry.

"I'm sorry," she said later, her voice coarse. "I truly am happy for you."

"I know," She-Ra murmured in her hair.

Catra didn't feel strong enough to let go yet, so she panicked when she started being pulled away. But She-Ra didn't make her go very far. She only put enough space between them so she could duck her face to kiss the top of Catra's head, her cheeks, her temple. The astonishment that came from it helped Catra recover as much as the gentle touches did. It was rare for She-Ra to initiate any kind of physical contact between them, though she didn't seem to have any problem when Catra did it, and they had certainly never been as bold with each other before.

Oblivious to the war of emotions erupting in the princess's mind, She-Ra contented herself with tugging her close again, making sure Catra's position was comfortable. Feeling safer, and more loved than she had in a long time, Princess Catra fell asleep in her arms. She-Ra let her sleep for a while before she woke her up.

"I'm afraid it is time for you to leave," she whispered, trying not to startle her.

"I wish I could stay here forever," Catra whispered back.

She-Ra didn't reply, so Catra picked herself up from her lap and prepared herself for the walk back. She rubbed at her face with the inside of her wrist.

"I'll help you figure something out. She can't do this to you, Catra. This is your kingdom."

A hollow chuckle left her chest. "Don't you see it? She already did."

She-Ra shook her head. “That’s not you. The Catra I know would never let her get away with this.”

“Maybe I’m tired. Maybe I want to give up. Leave all this behind.”

Gray eyes bored into her. Catra met her gaze, hoping they wouldn’t see the secrets she hid inside herself.

“Is that really what you want?”

And in that moment, Catra knew. She knew exactly what She-Ra was asking, what she was offering. Her dreams of running away, of finding a new life away from the castle, from the regent, from the empty promises of power, it wouldn’t have to be a dream anymore. She-Ra would help her. All Catra had to do was ask.

But she wouldn’t. She-Ra was right, that wasn’t who she was.

She let her eyes fall. “No.”

She-Ra took her hand, making her look up at her face again. “We’ll find a way, I promise.”

“You can’t promise something like that.”

But Princess Catra wasn’t the only one who didn’t know how to give up. She-Ra furrowed her brow, squeezing Catra’s hand in both of her own. “I promise anyway.”

That was She-Ra's most bittersweet visit yet. Catra’s tears dampened her tunic more than once. She encouraged the princess’s efforts to swing the court in her favor, but she also advised her to be careful. Catra recognized the shaking in She-Ra's hands at those words. She wasn’t the only one who felt helpless.

It wasn’t all bad. She-Ra did her best to take Catra’s mind off the castle. She joked, and she told stories, and she trained Catra in both swordplay and hand to hand combat as if nothing had

changed. Over the years, as the princess's life became harder and gloomier, She-Ra's presence in it only grew brighter.

"How did you even know I was saying the truth the first time we met? I wasn't dressed like royalty. I wasn't even wearing shoes!" Catra shook her head, smiling at the memory. "I could have been anyone. Should I be concerned about this? Do you still go around believing everything that people tell you?"

She-Ra giggled, ducking her head. Catra went on, so focused on teasing her friend that she never realized she hadn't actually answered the question, or even tried to defend herself from it.

There was, however, a piece of advice from She-Ra that proved to be invaluable. There was a woman at the court who Catra had been reluctant to seek out yet, but her friend managed to convince her to give it a try. Her name was Lady Entrapta of Dryl, and she was the regent's advisor.

The reasons for the princess to avoid her were clear. She was convinced nothing she could say would persuade the woman to favor Catra, and she wasn't sure she wanted that in the first place. After seeing what had become of her parent's most trusted advisor, Catra wasn't eager to rub elbows with another one.

As it turned out, it didn't take long after trying to get more closely acquainted with her, that Lady Entrapta couldn't be more different from Weaver. Lady Entrapta was only the last of the regent's advisors, having gone through a great number of them over the years. None of them seemed to keep their position for long, either too useless or too cunning for the regent's taste. Lady Entrapta wasn't, so far, the one who had held it the longest, but Catra could already tell that she wasn't like the ones before her.

Aside from being genuinely... odd as a person, what set Lady Entrapta apart was the way Regent Weaver behaved around her. Princess Catra was rarely privy to their conversations, but even from a distance she had unearthed a most important fact: Regent Weaver despised the woman. She was clearly unhappy with

having to put up with her and her antics, and yet, Lady Entrapta remained right where she was, and with a valuable title and considerable influence to boot.

It wasn't hard to gain Entrapta's friendship. After all, her main companion was the regent, and Princess Catra knew better than anyone the kind of treatment the woman gave. Entrapta only wanted people she could talk to, and Catra and Scorpia were more than eager to provide it to her. They made for a strange group, the three of them, but, somehow, it worked. One day Catra looked back and realized that, what had started as a calculated move on her part, had actually led her to caring about the advisor. Entrapta paid little attention to something as meaningless as decorum, and she was far more intelligent than anyone Catra had ever known. Following her thoughts on anything, from the kingdom's affairs to the history of royal garments, was fascinating.

The princess didn't know what to make of it. She didn't want to let herself be swayed by Entrapta, but at the same time she couldn't afford to lose the connection. To make matters worse, she had to thread carefully, as she was sure that, no matter how valuable Lady Entrapta was, the regent would get rid of her without a second thought if she so much as suspected Entrapta would put Catra over her in any way. Luckily for her, Weaver was smart, and she knew that Entrapta was more concerned with the kingdom's wellbeing than with any kind of infighting inside the castle. The princess never dared discuss her situation with her, afraid of having to find out exactly how much the regent was willing to put up with for the sake of keeping the best advisor she had ever had.

But the tension around the crown had never been meant to last, and the day finally arrived where things would change forever, as these stories usually go. For Princess Catra, this came in the form of a letter, handed personally to her at breakfast, where she was sitting at the table with Scorpia and Weaver.

Her Royal Highness, Princess Adora of Etheria accepts your offer and officializes her engagement to her Royal Highness, Princess Catra of D'riluth.

Despite her years learning to conceal her emotions, to tame her impulses, despite the deep-set disgust she felt at giving Weaver any kind of leverage over her, Catra got up and left the room. Not knowing where to go, she paced around the gardens for a while, but she soon had to head back inside. The castle looming at her back made her feel watcg

So this was it, Weaver's final move.

Catra should have seen it coming, but the truth was, she was expecting something different. Marrying her off was such an anticlimactic end. Not to mention that she couldn't believe the proposal had been accepted in the first place.

The story of Princess Adora of Etheria was, in more ways than one, a mirror of Catra's own. The flip side of a coin, the translation at the back of the page. When Princess Adora was almost three years old, Weaver had become the ruler of the Kingdom of D'riluth. Her first official act as the regent had been to give hunt to those responsible for the death of its monarchs.

She had traced the assassins back to their roots, and determined that the attack had been ordered by no-one else by the Queen and King of the neighboring kingdom, Etheria, in an attempt to undermine them. She gathered D'riluth's army and made them march west, where they ended storming the castle and executing the royal family.

The princess had been the only survivor. When their defenses had been breached, her parents had entrusted her to the head of their royal guard, a woman named Mara. Despite the vicious fighting, Mara had managed to escape the castle, taking the girl with her. They then had traveled clandestinely across the land, until they reached the kingdom of Bright Moon. There, Mara had left Princess Adora in the hands of Queen Angella and King Micah.

They both had been close friends to the monarchs of Etheria, and their kingdom was the safest place for the now homeless royal. Mara passed away soon after arriving at Bright Moon, having sustained injuries during the siege of the castle that hadn't had time to heal properly during their journey.

Letting the Etherian princess live had been the regent's first, and sole, act of mercy. There was, however, a condition that had to be upheld. Princess Adora could never return to her land, and never claim the right to govern it for herself. Queen Angella and King Micah had accepted those terms on her behalf, and thus taken her into their family, making Bright Moon her new home. Etheria was annexed to the Kingdom of D'riluth, and the regent declared that the blood debt was settled.

Catra had never bought that story. People seemed to forget that, young as she had been, the princess had been present at the moment of her parent's demise. Nightmares of bloodied wings, dripping wet and hot on her skin, had been a constant for most of her life. That hadn't actually happened, of course, but it didn't take long for Catra to link those images to the coat of arms of The Horde, the most proficient mercenary across the lands, once she had learned of their existence.

It was certainly interesting how, with Regent Weaver in power, their influence had grown, and their assets had seemed to multiply as if conjured by magic.

As for Princess Adora, as far as Catra knew, she was still in Bright Moon, being educated alongside Angela and Micah's daughter as if they were sisters. It was rare, and understandably so, to get word about her over at D'riluth's court. Some rumors suggested Queen Angella intended to make a general out of her, possibly even put her in charge of Bright Moon's army in the future.

Catra would be lying if she said she hadn't found herself wondering about her in passing over the years. The princess without a kingdom, whose fate had been so intermingled with Catra's own without any act on either of their parts. She supposed

it was ironic, that they would end up like this. It didn’t make sense for her to accept Regent Weaver’s proposal. Princess Adora could never get control of her kingdom, she couldn’t even walk back into it without risking being executed. An offer of marriage from Catra should have felt, in all regards, like a slap in the face. A taunt, a mocking and cruel gesture.

But she had accepted, and she had doomed Catra along with her. She wouldn’t be allowed to take the crown, not if she was married to Princess Adora. She would be forced out of the castle. Did Adora know this? Had Weaver deceived her, promised her kingdom back only to deny it to her at the last minute? But no, she had to know. Was this revenge, then? A way to get back at Catra? To tie them together so that if she couldn't have what was hers, then Catra couldn’t either?

In the end, Catra knew what she had to do.

Her misstep at breakfast was the last time they saw Catra falter. As wedding preparations started around the castle, she made sure to never be caught unprepared. Every action thought through long before it was taken, every word calculated. The princess could not afford to lose her chance by raising suspicions. So each day was treated and performed, as normal as the last, as unassuming as the next. She bided her time.

It took her over two weeks to be able to leave the castle without anyone noticing. Once she found herself in the town, she made her way over to Razz’s house. She knocked on the door, being careful not to disturb the flowers. It was uncommon for Razz to be inside at that hour, however, and Catra was about to slide the letter under the door and hope she’d see it, when it opened.

She-Ra stood in front of her, gray eyes widening in recognition when she saw her.

“I was hoping it’d be you,” she said before she ushered Catra inside.

Catra didn't wait for the door to be closed behind her before she said, "We need to leave."

"Leave?"

"Not now, of course, but soon. Did you just arrive? Will you be staying until the end of the season? I think it's safe to stay that long, but we might have to do it earlier if things don't go according to plan, would that be ok?"

"Catra-"

"I'll need you to shop for supplies, but don't worry, I have some coin I've managed to get my hands on. Maybe–"

"Catra!" She-Ra said, raising her voice. "I need you to slow down."

Catra sighed. She took a seat, and signaled for She-Ra to do the same. "I'm getting married. To Princess Adora."

"And you want to run?"

"Of course I want to run! What else am I supposed to do? To go along with this humiliation? To give up my kingdom, my home? My parent's home! To smile and nod and do everything that witch expects me to do? No. The least I can do is leave, deprive her of the satisfaction."

She-Ra shook her head. "You don't mean that. You love your kingdom, I know you do."

Cold spread all over Catra's neck. What if She-Ra didn't want to leave with her? All these years, she thought they were on the same page. She thought She-Ra knew, that she knew what her life was like, what her stakes were. That she knew... that she wanted.... but no, of course not. There was no-one on the whole land who wanted Catra. And She-Ra was a knight, what did Catra expect her to do? To risk everything she had worked for to harbor a fugitive princess?

She got up. “It’s fine, I’ll figure out another way. I can’t stay here, I need to go, I need–”

She approached the door, but She-Ra got in her way. “You don’t need to do that. Please sit down, let us talk about this.”

Catra bit her lips, her eyes straying to the door. She could run from this too.

“Let me help you, please.”

She sat back. She-Ra didn’t smile, not exactly, but her shoulders relaxed, if just a little. Now that she looked at her, Catra realized how tense she was. She wouldn’t stop twisting her hands, and once she sat down her leg started bouncing in place too. There were worry lines around her eyes and her hair was pulled back so tightly, it looked like it hurt.

“If you want to run,” She-Ra said, “we will. Just say the word and we’ll be out of here. But the life you’ll have with me is not the life you think will be.”

“What does that mean?” Catra said, brow furrowing. “You are a knight. You live somewhere far away from here. You have your aunt, your uncle, and your sister to look after you. That’s all I know about your life, you’ve never told me more.”

“And that is all true, but that’s also not all my life is.” She-Ra pursed her lips, looking up at the ceiling for a couple of seconds. “I can explain it to you, if you want, and I will if you want to come with me, of course, but if you don’t then... then I think it’s better if you leave it at that for now.”

Catra brought her hand to her hip. “Are you working with her?”

She-Ra jumped in place, looking like she had been struck. “Of course not! I would never do that!”

“Then what are you hiding?”

“Do you really want to know? Because if I tell you right now, you won’t like it, and I don’t know if you’ll let me help you after that.”

She threw her hands in the air. “Then how do you expect me to trust you!”

Her friend lowered her head. “I’ll do whatever you see best, princess. Just know, I would never want to harm you in any way.”

Catra glared at her. She didn’t understand what was happening. Sure, She-Ra had always been reserved when talking about her life and her origins, but Catra couldn’t imagine anything that would warrant this type of reaction. She already knew She-Ra was nobility. Was her family close to the regent? Was that why she was scared? But then,if that were true, she would have told her so when Catra had accused her of working with Weaver, wouldn’t she?

“What do you propose I do, then?” she finally said.

She-Ra raised her gaze, with surprise in her eyes. “So you’ll let me help you?”

“You are my best friend, is it that shocking that I’m choosing to trust you?” She crossed her arms. “You still haven’t explained what this ‘help’ would be.”

“I know Princess Adora,” She-Ra said in a rush.

“Is that why you are being so odd?”

It would make sense. Bright Moon qualified as being far away, and it would explain why Catra had never managed to figure out which family she belonged to. Perhaps she didn’t want Catra to think she would betray her for her kingdom. She-Ra kept her mouth shut, wiggling uncomfortably in her seat.

“Right, don’t tell me, I don’t want to know. What makes you think she’d want to help me, then?”

She-Ra raised an eyebrow. “Why wouldn’t she? Regent Weaver has taken everything from her too.”

“She doesn’t even know me. For all I know, she accepted Weaver’s proposal to purposely ruin my life.”

“Or, she accepted it because she recognizes you are in danger too and she wanted to give you a safe place.”

“You are asking me to put an awfully lot of trust on someone I have never met.”

“What I’m asking, princess,” said She-Ra, gray eyes as earnest as they’ve always been, “is for you to trust me. Trust that I know what I’m doing. I promised, years ago, that I’d find a way to help you, remember?”

Catra looked at her. Her best friend, her first friend, her first love, her only love. She’d cut off her own hand if She-Ra asked for it, and she’d find a way to cut both if she told her it would give her back her kingdom.

“Tell me your plan.”

It was strange, going back to the castle that day. When she had left it, she had thought it marked the first step on the journey that would take her far, far away from it. Now, for the first time, the echo of her shoes against the floor didn’t feel like the mocking laugh of a place that knew she didn’t belong. She made her way through the corridors, a determined expression firmly in place, the same one she had seen on She-Ra's face when they had parted that afternoon. She would return to Bright Moon that same night, as the wedding was approaching, and they had no time to waste. Catra refused to think that it might be the last time she’d ever see her.

“Entrapta, dear, if we were to plan a rebellion right under the regent’s nose, you wouldn’t feel compelled to tell her, would you now?”

Shoving Entrapta and Scorpia into an empty room had been a challenge, but Catra hadn't spent most of her life getting to know every hidden corner of the castle for nothing. The hardest part had been relocating Entrapta without her getting distracted, or alerting someone by mistake.

"It's not technically a rebellion if it's organized by the crowned princess. I think." She rubbed her chin as she pondered over the semantics of the word.

Catra stopped carding her fingers through Entrapta's hair. "Just answer the question, please."

"No, I wouldn't. The odds of a coup against her being successful, however..."

"Are abysmal, I know."

"I have a question," Scorpia said, raising her hand in the air. "When you say we, you mean...?"

"Yes, you too."

Scorpia lowered her hand. "Oh, great!"

Catra shifted her weight, looking at both of them. "First, Entrapta will suggest to Weaver that we should write to the Fright Zone, tell them to send reinforcements to our army, in case Bright Moon attempts anything during the wedding."

"That's already the regent's plan."

A smirk broke out in Catra's face. "Excellent, I was hoping that'd be the case. All that's left is Scorpia, then, who needs to infforeorm her mothers of our intentions without alerting Weaver."

"And I will definitely do that, Wildcat, you know I will. But uh...how do I say this... you know the Fright Zone doesn't have enough forces to be a threat to the castle by itself."

“Does this mean you don’t like the plan where you marry Princess Adora?”

Catra blinked twice, all other thoughts suddenly vanishing from her head. “Wait, that was you?”

Entrapta nodded. “The regent was thinking along more...violent routes, I believe, to remove you from the crown. At least that’s what inferred from her innuendos, which I’m now much more proficient at understanding. I don’t know why she chooses such an inefficient form of communication,” she mused. “In any case,” she continued, remembering that she had been in the middle of an explanation, “I thought you’d find marriage a more comfortable alternative.”

Now Catra didn’t have enough maids to help unpack all that. “...thank you, Entrapta, I do. But I still prefer the option where I actually get to rule my parent’s kingdom.”

Both women started protesting at the same time. Catra quieted them with a look. Well, with a look and, in the case from Entrapta, an elbow to the side and a sign to be quiet from Scorpia.

“I know that the Fright Zone forces aren’t enough to represent a real threat to Weaver, but that’s what the Bright Moon Army is for.”

Scorpia and Entrapta opened up their mouths, then closed them again. Catra had to admit, this was the most fun she had had in a while. But it was time to get serious.

“Princess Adora is going to help me take back my kingdom.”

“I have so many questions,” said Scorpia. “How do you even know Princess Adora?”

“I don’t,” she admitted, “but She-Ra does.”

“Ooooh is this the She-Ra who you meet when you sneak out of the castle?” asked Entrapta, getting close to Catra’s face.

“Scorpia! You said you wouldn’t tell!”

Scorpia fidgeted with the edge of her dress. “It might have slipped out. You know how bad I am with secrets! But I didn’t tell her everything, don’t worry.”

“Wait!” yelled Entrapta. “Is that why you could never figure out which noble family she belonged to? Because she’s Bright Moon nobility?”

Catra glared at Scorpia, who tried to hide behind Entrapta.

“I’m sorry!”

She sighed. If anything, this proved for once and for all that Entrapta was to be trusted. If she weren’t, word of She-Ra would have already reached Weaver. Catra didn’t imagine she would take that information quietly. “Yes, that She-Ra. And that’s what I figure too, not that she told me anything about it. She just said that she knew the princess, and that she’d help us.”

“And how do you know if that’s true?”

“I don’t.”

“And how do you know Princess Adora will agree to help you?”

“I don’t know that either.”

“And how do you know she’s not going to use this as an opportunity to reclaim this whole kingdom for herself?”

Catra’s nostrils flared. “I don’t, okay!” She took a deep breath, and flattened out the front of her robe with the palms of her hands, like she’d seen She-Ra do when she was trying to compose herself. “But She-Ra said she’d do it, and I trust her.”

Entrapta looked ready to make another question, but Scorpia elbowed her on the side again, this time accompanying it with a shake of her head.

“We’ll do whatever you need, Wildcat. We are here for you.”

Entrapta nodded along with her and then, finally, they stopped asking questions, and they could start discussing the finest details of their plan.

Once that was done, there wasn’t much left for the princess but to wait for her wedding day to arrive. Sure, there was still some scheming and conniving to do, trying to sway whoever she could to her side. But most of that was conducted by Scorpia and even, on occasion, Entrapta, as it was too risky for Catra to handle it herself, though she was always the one behind it.

No, most of what Catra could actually do was sit, and smile, and nod, and lie through her teeth. And above all, wait.

Until finally, she didn’t have to wait anymore. The day before Princess Catra’s wedding, she awoke with a start, her grip on the dagger tightening. She got up and got dressed by herself, having long ago dismissed her maids. The whole morning she spent on edge, about to spring from her seat at any sound of footsteps approaching.

Her presence was requested by the regent, and, as Catra made her way over there, she tried to shake off the sticky feeling that permeated all her senses, making it seem like she was living the most vivid of dreams. It certainly didn’t help that, when she stepped into the room where she was expecting to meet Princess Adora, what greeted her was the familiar face of her childhood friend, She-Ra.

She was wearing travel clothing, but its cut and material were better than anything Catra had ever seen on her. Her hair, at least, was styled back in its usual fashion, a detail that helped ground Catra more than it should have been possible. She had hesitated for a second when coming in, but she quickly turned to face Weaver, hoping that it had gone unnoticed.

The regent smiled, all tight lips and hidden teeth. “Catra, how nice of you to finally join us. It’s about time you two met.”

She-Ra turned towards her, lowering her head. “I’m Adora of Etheria, your Highness.”

Catra had never had the chance to meet another royal, but she knew that that wasn’t the standard greeting when meeting a peer. “I’m Catra,” she said, lost at what was expected of her.

She heard Weaver sneer at her lack of decorum, but it didn’t matter. Soon, nothing Weaver did would ever matter.

She-Ra straightened herself. Their eyes met, and Catra felt like things were starting to fall into place. She-Ra was here, and she’d look out for Catra, the same way Catra would do for her. She-Ra did nothing to hide the soft smile gracing her lips, but Catra wasn’t so lucky. She didn’t want to give any warning to the regent that things might not be going as she had planned. Before breaking their gaze, She-Ra winked at her, making Catra have to swallow a snort. She-Ra could not wink, which in this case was a good thing, because there was no way Weaver could have seen her weird expression and take it as any form of secret message.

“And this is my companion, Sir Bow,” She-Ra said, gesturing to the man next to her.

He bowed, and gave her the accustomed greeting, to which she replied in kind. She wanted to stick her tongue out at She-Ra and say *see? Why couldn’t you behave, like him?* They’d have time for that later. For now...

“You must have had a difficult trip, why don’t you go freshen up before dinner?”

Weaver waved a hand, and two guards who Catra hadn’t noticed standing nearby approached them, positioning themselves behind She-Ra and Sir Bow. Alarm bells rang out in her head, something about the situation reading completely wrong with her. This really wasn’t the way Catra expected this to go, but she was tired of

being bullied and pushed around. It was time for Weaver to be the vulnerable one for once.

Before anyone could stop her, she cut the distance between her and the regent, drawing her dagger from within her dress as she did so. Like she had practiced a million times before with She-Ra, she threw herself at her with all her strength, tackling Weaver to the ground. She stood up behind her and grabbed Weaver by the back of her head, resting the knife against her throat.

Far from being concerned with her new position, Weaver left out a snide chuckle. “So it has come to this.”

“What, did you really expect me to hand over my crown to you without a fight?”

Weaver laughed more fully this time. “No, I expected you to present an actual challenge. But I should have known you wouldn’t be good enough for that either.”

The guards behind She-Ra and Bow stepped forward, grabbing them and restraining their arms. More guards entered the room, forming a circle around the four of them. For a second, Catra’s heart faltered. Weaver was right, she couldn’t do this. Weaver had been better than her her whole life. She had been better than her parents. All Catra had done was condemn herself, and bring She-Ra down with her.

Then she locked eyes with She-Ra, who seemed perfectly at ease with the whole situation. She nodded at her, and it was like she had breathed air back into Catra’s lungs. She-Ra trusted her, and Catra trusted her, and that was enough. That was all she needed.

“You seriously want to play it like this? You think I won’t do it?” Catra asked, letting the blade sink deeper into Weaver’s skin. “You’ve made my life miserable. You have taken everything from me. My parents, my life, my home. You think I’m not just waiting for an excuse to kill you with my own hands?”

“If you do that, then neither you nor your friends are getting out of here alive.”

The guards around them got closer, hands on their swords, because of course Weaver couldn’t pass the opportunity to make a big spectacle.

“I rather die than let you win.”

“That might be true, but are you willing to risk the lives of your... friends?”

Despite herself, her grip on the regent slackened minutely. She rectified it quickly, but it was no use, Weaver had noticed. Catra wanted to scream. It had been little more than a shot in the dark, she was sure of it, but she had gone ahead and given herself away anyway.

“If Scorpia and Entrapta don’t hear from us soon, then the Fright Zone forces stationed here will come in my aid.”

“You think you are the only one who infiltrated the castle?”

“And what are you going to do when Bright Moon goes to war?”

Weaver scoffed, “Bright Moon has never been suited for war. And now they’ve delivered one of their most important generals and their Tech Master to my door. Angella knows we’d crush them, she wouldn’t dare.”

Catra gritted her teeth. “You have an answer for everything, don’t you?” Always one step ahead of her, that’s how it had always been.

“Catra... stop this nonsense. Put that thing away and stop behaving like a child. Don’t you see it? I’m giving you a way out. Marry the princess, leave this land, and I’ll let you live the rest of your life in peace. Give up, we all know royal life doesn’t suit you anyway.”

“Oh, shut up,” said She-Ra.

Weaver fixed her eyes on her, “Excuse me?”

“You underestimate Catra, you always have.”

“Who do you think you are–”

“Are we done here, your Highness?” asked She-Ra, ignoring her.

She loved her so much. “We are.”

Catra only got a second to enjoy the sight of She-Ra's smirk before she started moving. She flung her head back, hitting the guard holding her on the face. At the same time, she twisted her arms, breaking the grip on them. Everyone around them went into a flurry of activity, and Catra made sure to pull strongly at Weaver’s hair, exposing her neck even more, and drawing attention to the dagger against it. It worked, and the circle of guards hesitated. Their swords were drawn, but they didn’t seem to know what step should come next.

That was all She-Ra needed to finish disposing of her holder. She grabbed him by the shoulders and pushed him towards the man gripping Bow, who had tried to move aside when She-Ra broke free. Both men fell to the ground, Bow sidestepping them politely. He bent over and retrieved the swords from their sheaths before they could recover. He threw one of them at She-Ra, who caught it midair.

They stood back to back, swords ready, challenging the guards to get closer.

“Now, do you want to reconsider your stance on this matter?”

She did.

By the time night fell, Princess Catra’s story was over, and Queen Catra’s had just begun. Weaver was stripped of her title and locked up in the dungeons until the queen could decide on an

appropriate fate for her. Given that Catra didn't feel inclined to waste her time thinking about the former regent, it could be a while before that happened.

Most of the day had been spent rounding up guards and verifying if they were subjects of the crown or impostors hired by Weaver. The influx of reinforcements from the Fright Zone meant that the process was harder than it should have been, but in the end everyone's identity had been double checked and Catra felt that she could finally be at ease. To the surprise of everyone but her, the fake guards turned out to be Horde members, wings branded on their arms.

She-Ra insisted on escorting her around all day. It did make Catra feel safer, but that didn't stop her from teasing her friend about how paranoid she was being. Then, of course, a rogue spy they hadn't apprehended yet had actually tried to stab her, and Catra couldn't laugh about it anymore. She-Ra had taken care of him and no harm had come to the new queen, but She-Ra had received a superficial wound when pushing her out of the way. Catra had tried asking her to rest after the encounter, but She-Ra had stubbornly refused to leave her side.

As soon as the dust had settled, and there were no more urgent matters to attend to, the queen ordered food and medicine to be brought to her chambers. She hadn't even had to ask for She-Ra to join her, she had walked in all on her own. The two guards from the Fright Zone that Scorpia had assigned to her stayed posted at her door, and Catra struggled not to dismiss them. She-Ra was right, the castle wasn't safe for her yet. It would probably take some time before it was. She-Ra had already gotten hurt because of her, and she wouldn't let it happen again.

It felt strange, finally being alone with She-Ra. They hadn't left each other's company all day, but that had been different. People had been around them. Her friends, guards, courtiers, and servants. She was still getting used to seeing her here, in the place that represented both all of Catra's nightmares and all of her dreams. Catra had changed into her best clothes for a rushed

coronation, and the multiple layers of cloth and embellishments felt restrictive on her.

“Let me clean your wound again.”

She-Ra shook her head. “I can take care of it.”

Catra leveled her with a look and pointed to her bed. She-Ra rolled her eyes, but complied. Catra kneeled in front of her, carefully unwrapping the bandage on her arm. She dampened a piece of cloth and applied it to She-Ra's skin.

“It looks bad, but it’s only superficial,” She-Ra said softly.

Catra didn’t reply, preferring to give her whole attention to the task at hand. It did look bad. Catra had never seen an injury like it before. But the medics had said the same thing, so she supposed she’d have to trust them.

They stayed in silence as Catra worked. It wasn’t uncomfortable, but the air did feel charged. Catra wondered if she was the only one who noticed. When she dared look up, she found She-Ra's soft gaze waiting for her. She quickly lowered her eyes again. For once, Catra had no idea how to behave in front of her friend. She was finally free to choose her own destiny. Was she brave enough to pursue it?

“So, Princess Adora, huh?” she finally said, hoping that familiar act of teasing would land her close of where she wanted to be.

She-Ra chuckled. “I told you it was a big secret.”

The cloth slipped from Catra’s hand, landing on the water bowl and splashing her skirt. She didn’t even notice.

“What?”

She-Ra looked confusedly at her. She opened her mouth, then closed it again, a frown appearing at her brow. “Wait, you thought...”

“You are...”

“I’m sorry, I thought you knew...”

Catra groaned, hiding her face in her hands. “I’m an idiot.”

Above her, Adora was growing agitated. “No, it’s my fault, I assumed, and I didn’t say anything, and...”

“Stop flailing your arms around! You are hurt!”

She smacked her arms to her sides, which wasn’t exactly ideal either, then stayed frozen in place. “Sorry!”

Catra glared. “Well, you are an idiot too so at least it balances out.” Adora opened her mouth, but she cut her off. “If you say sorry one more time, I’m leaving you to dress your wound on your own.”

“I actually wanted to do that, you are the one who...” Adora took a deep breath. “Whatever you say.” A mischievous glint took over her eyes. “In any case, I’m Princess Adora of Etheria, and it’s an honor to properly meet you, Your Majesty.”

Catra shook her head. “I can’t believe you’ve been teasing me for being a princess all these years, when you are one too.”

“Oh, you love it.” Adora reached with her non-injured arm, grabbing a hold of Catra’s hand. The contact was warm, and Catra couldn’t help but look directly into her eyes. “I would never do anything to make you uncomfortable, my Queen.”

Catra let go of her hand and ducked, searching for the forgotten cloth in an attempt to hide her reddening cheeks. It was embarrassing, really. She was a queen for crying out loud. She shouldn’t be turning red and forgetting how to breathe over hearing her own title. Adora had been doing this to her for years, shouldn’t she be immune to it by now?

As she focused back on Adora's wound, more important questions made their way into her mind.

"Wait. If you are...you know," she waved a hand vaguely signaling at her whole person, "what were you even doing here all these years? To come here, right under Weaver's nose..."

Adora waited until Catra had finished tying up the new bandage in place, then sat further back onto the bed, tucking her legs under her. She patted the space in front of her. Catra took a second to set away the used cloth and water before joining her.

"Razz was my nursemaid, back before my family... She had been away at the time of the siege. According to Angella, when she heard where Mara had planned to take me, she made her way to Bright Moon, managed to sneak into the castle, and got into the kids' room before she got caught. She was lucky Micah was the one who found her when he went to check on Glimmer and me."

"That explains absolutely nothing."

Adora huffed. "I'm getting there. You are a queen now, you can't be this impatient."

She stuck her tongue out at her. "Bite me."

To her surprise, Adora smirked. "If that's what my Queen desires..."

She deliberately leaned closer, and Catra had to push her face away.

She hoped the shrillness in her voice passed for impatience. "Get on with the story already!"

It took a few seconds for Adora's laugh to subside. "Angella and Micah considered that it would be good for me to be around someone from home. Razz had been taking care of me since I had been born, like she had done with my brother, and with my father before us. She stayed in the castle for the first couple of years,

but then she decided she had to leave. She wanted to come here."

Catra couldn't help but interrupt. "Why?"

Adora shrugged. "Who knows, she's Razz," she said, like that explained it, and, given that Catra had spent plenty of time around her over the years, she conceded it did.

"That doesn't explain how you ended up here."

"She wanted to take me with her, which of course Angella and Micah didn't consent to. Apparently, there was a huge argument, they both still get very tense when they talk about it. I can't even imagine how Razz did it, but the point is that in the end they agreed to let me travel here once a year to spend some time with her." She raised a hand to stop Catra from talking. "Don't even say it, I know it's the dumbest thing you've ever heard. Believe me, they know. They agonized over it all the time. They still do."

Robbed of expressing her only thought about the matter, she pointed out, "You visited her many more times than once a year."

Adora smiled. "I had a very good reason, but I guess you're right. I'm dumb too."

The intensity in her eyes was suffocating. At first, Catra thought things would shift between them, but that hadn't happened. Adora, She-Ra, princess, knight, it was all the same. Her title didn't change the way Catra's heart raced every time she saw her, or how she ached when she missed her. She was as beautiful as she had ever been no matter the type of tunic she wore. Her hair was still pulled back a bit too tight for comfort. Her smile made warmth blossom in Catra's chest, and at her side was the safest Catra had ever been.

"I'm not going to argue with you on that."

"Your Majesty is so rude," said Adora, the back of her hand going to rest against her forehead.

“Stop moving your arm so much! It needs to heal!”

“Is Your Majesty, The Queen, worried about a humble servant such as me?”

Catra decided to ignore her. “So you befriending me was exactly the opposite thing of what you should have been doing, then?”

Adora smiled sheepishly. “I guess. I knew the adults wouldn’t like it, which was why we had to hide from Razz those first years, remember? But then she saw us one afternoon. At first, she thought you were just a regular kid, but I felt guilty so I confessed the whole thing to her. The only thing she said was ‘tomorrow, you bring her inside.’”

“You realize you should be dead, right? You should have died at least a dozen times already.”

“We aren’t complete idiots, you know? We did think this through and devise plans and strategies, and... nothing I can say is going to change your mind, will it?”

Catra shrugged. “Not really.”

To think that all that time, Adora had been putting herself at risk just to spend time with her. Catra had always known there was danger surrounding them, but she never imagined that Adora could be potentially facing death at her expense. She assumed the worst would fall to her, being sentenced to a life of restrictions and never to be allowed any liberties again. Catra had accepted that possibility, but as it turned out, Adora’s gamble had been even greater.

“I’m sorry I lied. Especially since you were always honest with me. But Angella and Micah had made me promise a million times I would never tell anyone who I was, and then I grew up and I realized how dangerous it was, for us to meet like that, and then you didn’t get the crown, and I don’t know. I was scared.”

“Of what?”

"Of Weaver finding out and taking you down with me. But no, not only of that. I was also scared, terrified of you being angry with me. I told myself it'd be better to wait until you were crowned, when I'd known you'd be taken care of. When I'd be sure..." Adora bit her lip. "When I'd be sure you wouldn't need me anymore."

"Adora, I'm not angry. A little heads up before today would have been nice, since I could have ruined our whole plan."

As she had hoped, the guilt disappeared from Adora's face. She arched an eyebrow. "Right, because the plan had always been to threaten Weaver at knife point until she handed back your kingdom."

Catra scowled. "Excuse me for getting things done. And do you notice that that actually proves my point?"

Adora laughed, shaking her head. Then, she leaned forward, resting her forehead against Catra's. "I'm so proud of you, what you did was amazing."

Adora had closed her eyes and, despite the lack of space between them, Catra could see the smile gracing her lips. She tried to get herself to reply, but no words came out of Catra's mouth. Adora's proximity was intoxicating. There was finally nothing standing between them. No more Weaver, no more secrets, no more hidden threats.

Her agitation was sensed by Adora, who drew back, a concerned frown on her face. "What's wrong?"

To say that Catra panicked was an understatement. "You never touched me like this before."

As soon as the words left her mouth, she wanted to smack herself in the face. Could she have been more inappropriate? Probably not. Now she wasn't the only one who was flushed and flustered.

"I apologize, I was too forward–"

Catra rushed to silence her. “Don’t be daft, that’s not what I mean. I just thought...”

She trailed off, not sure of how to properly express herself. She had been wanting this for so long, how could it be that she still didn’t find the words to express it? Was she scared? Of course she was scared. This was Adora, her best friend, the one she loved. If she lost her now... If she lost her now, Catra didn’t know what she would do.

Her explanation did manage to do some good though, as Adora’s expression cleared. “I didn’t think it was fair. You didn’t know the truth about me.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Always so chivalrous.”

Her tone left no doubt about her sarcastic meaning, yet Adora still took it as a compliment. She bowed her head. “I am a knight, after all.”

“That’s not all that you are.”

Adora gave her an inquisitive look, silently gesturing for her to keep going.

“You are a princess,” Catra clarified, rather uselessly.

“A princess without a kingdom,” Adora corrected. “I rather be a knight with her army.”

Barely noticing it herself, Catra leaned forward, kneeling on the bed. “You could have a kingdom, if you wanted to. Your kingdom.”

Adora took one of her hands. “That’s not what I want, Catra. That’s not why I did any of this.”

But wouldn’t letting her feelings go unanswered be the same as losing her? If she didn’t speak up now, then when? Catra had spent her whole life in the shadows, waiting for the time to strike,

hoping no one would get a jump on her first. She didn’t want that to be her life anymore. She wanted to walk in the light, with Adora. If she’d allow it. She looked at their joined hands, and took the first step forward.

“That’s not what I meant.”

“Then what...”

Her grip on Adora’s hand got tighter despite herself. “You could rule with me, by my side. Not a princess, but a queen.”

Adora’s confused expression would have been endearing if it wasn’t such a critical moment in Catra’s life. “Are you asking me to marry you?”

“You are, technically, my fiancée,” she said, crossing her arms.

She couldn’t help it. What if she was making a mistake? Was if this was how she lost Adora? Not because of Weaver, not because of the distance, but because she was the one who pushed her away? Could Adora really want her that way? If there was anything about life Catra knew, was that things never went her way. Everything she loved got taken away, destroyed, ruined. Why would Adora be anything different?

Unbeknownst of Catra’s inner crisis, Adora seemed to have one of her own. She sat back farther on the bed and spoke quickly, barely stopping for air on her tirade.“We don’t need to go through with that, I never expected you to. If this is your way of repaying me for what I’ve done, you don't need to. You are my best friend, and I’d do anything for you, and I didn’t technically do anything. It was all you, and-”

Wasn’t the fact that they were both here, Catra still in her coronation gown, the proof that things didn’t have to be that way anymore? Wasn't that what Adora had been trying to teach her for years? Adora had promised her to look after her, and she had. She had promised to help her get her kingdom back, and she had

done that too. Catra had always had to fight for the things she wanted. Couldn't she do that one last time?

Her friend was still going on about what she thought Catra needed or didn't need to do. She went quiet instantly as Catra cupped her face in her hands. Color dusted her cheeks, and Catra let herself believe she didn't have anything to fear.

"Adora. I love you. I always have. I want you to stay here with me. I can't take being apart from you anymore, so please, stay."

Adora's eyes went huge at the admission. No one said anything for several seconds and, as Catra discovered, that was fine. It didn't matter if Adora didn't return her feelings. All she wanted was for her to be happy, and for her to know how important she was to Catra. Adora had risked everything for her, and the least Catra could do was be honest for her. Catra's life had been so full of lies so far, she didn't want to keep on living that way.

"I love you too," she finally heard. "I want to stay with you."

Before she could think anything else, Adora was already leaning forward and capturing her lips in a kiss.

Queen Catra's story began, purportedly, the moment she was crowned as the rightful ruler of her kingdom. But in truth, her story had begun much earlier than that. Despite the unfortunate circumstances surrounding her life, Catra had been royalty since the moment she was born, and she had been fit for ruling from long before she had risen with a crown in her head and a scepter on her hand.

Her life was touched by death, and pain, and suffering, but it was not defined by it. At its core one would find love and bravery and loyalty. Loyalty for her kingdom, bravery for herself, and love for her one true queen, Adora. A love so strong it survived against all odds, that conquered even that which felt unconquerable. That is why the story of their love is still being told today.

The rest of their lives, though much more uneventful, was spent in the purest form of bliss. One might even say that they lived happily ever after.

End Notes

It’s important to me that you know how the peeps over at Bright Moon reacted when Weaver’s letter offering Catra’s hand in marriage arrived.

Angella: “I’ve had ENOUGH of this woman, HOW DARE SHE think we are just going to let Princess Catra marry Adora without giving her any rights to her OWN kingdom after she STOLE IT from her, I mean she’s the reason her parents were MURDERED. This is the most DISRESPECTFUL and EVIL thing I’ve ever SEEN.”

Glimmer: “I say we kill her.”

King Micah: “Now now dear, that’s no way to-”

Angella: “No, she has a point. Where’s the general? Can you get her in? Can we get the army ready?”

Glimmer: *fist pumps, starts talking strategy with her mom*

(by strategy I mean all the ways they fantasize about marching up inside the castle and threatening Weaver with their own swords for all the pain she has caused Adora.)

Adora: *walks into the room, finds the chaos* *whispers to Bow* what’s going on?

Bow: a letter might have arrived offering Princess Catra of D'riluth's hand in marriage to you, but also clearly stating that you’d get absolutely no political power from it, and we also suspect it’s just a move to remove the princess from her own kingdom, and now apparently we are going to war

Adora, half listening, already writing back a reply that consists only of the word YES in huge, bold letters: oh ok, yeah, sounds good

Ok so at this point y'all are probably tired of my words lol but seriously I worked so hard on this and I'm so proud of myself!!! Like, I didn't even know I COULD write such a long fic in such a like, cohesive way???? Guys I wrote this on less than a WEEK. For me that's as close to a miracle as I'll ever get. And people have had SUCH a nice response to this, thank you so much <3

Works inspired by this one: Limitations of the Post Office by Urist

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!